THE BATTLE OF ACTIUM

The Battle of Actium was the climax of the great power struggle between Mark Antony and Octavian for the leadership of the Roman world following the assassination of Julius Caesar in 44 BCE. In the summer of 31 BCE the forces of Antony and his Egyptian ally Cleopatra were cornered by Octavian at Actium, a Roman colony on the Greek coast. Octavian's admiral, Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa, who commanded a battle-hardened Roman fleet, pinned Antony's fleet in harbor with a close blockade and cut his supply line from Egypt. This allowed Octavian to ferry an army from Italy across the Adriatic unchallenged and to confront Antony on land.

DESPERATE MEASURES

By August, Antony's soldiers and seamen had run desperately short of food and other supplies, their ranks decimated by desertion and disease. Antony and Cleopatra devised a plan for a breakout by sea, hoping to escape back to Egypt with as much as possible of their treasure and their army. Many of their ships were in poor condition and, even after sending out press-gangs to round up able-bodied locals, they were short of oarsmen. Although the least seaworthy ships were burned, the rest were still undermanned.

The breakout was planned for August 29, but four days of storms delayed the operation until the morning of September 2. Antony led his war galleys out of harbor, while transport vessels loaded with treasure remained in the rear under Cleopatra's command. Most unusually, all of Antony's galleys had their masts and sails on board—normally these were never carried into battle. The plan was to exploit the expected offshore breeze from the north in order to sail off to Egypt and safety.

Throughout the morning there was a stand-off, Antony's fleet staying inshore and waiting for the wind. Then, as Agrippa's ships attempted to outflank their enemy, battle was joined. The squadron that included Antony's flagship, on the right of his line, was especially hotly engaged.

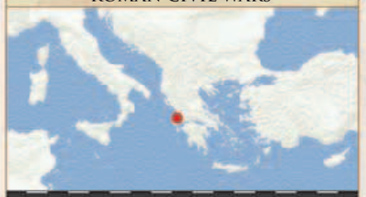
AN UNEQUAL CONTEST

Agrippa's host of small warships, mostly liburnians, were far nimbler than Antony's hefty quinqueremes, however these larger galleys provided a high platform for catapults and for soldiers with bows, spears, and slingshots. Ships grappled closely, many set aflame by incendiary devices such as fire arrows. In the afternoon the long-awaited breeze got up and Cleopatra seized the opportunity to sail her ships through the center of the blockading line, which had thinned as battle raged on the flanks. Deserting his flagship, which had been grappled by the enemy, for a lighter vessel, Antony sped after the Egyptian queen. Few of his warships were able to follow. The leaderless fleet fought on for a while until, heavily battered, it surrendered. Antony and Cleopatra reached Alexandria with around 60 vessels, but, the following summer, abandoned by almost all his troops, and facing defeat, Antony committed suicide. A week later Cleopatra did the same.



Antony and Cleopatra
Cleopatra was the last of the dynasty of pharaohs founded by Ptolemy, one of Alexander the Great's generals. In order to prevent Egypt from falling to Rome, she used her legendary charms to seduce first Julius Caesar, then Mark Antony.

ROMAN CIVIL WARS



THE BATTLE OF ACTIUM

Date	September 2, 31 BCE
Location	Ionian Sea, off the Gulf of Abracia, western Greece
Result	Decisive victory for Octavian

COMBATANTS

OCTAVIAN	MARK ANTONY CLEOPATRA VII

COMMANDERS

Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa	Mark Antony

FORCES

Ships: 400 warships, mostly liburnians and triremes	**Ships:** 230 warships, mostly quinqueremes

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships**: unknown	**Men:** 5,000 dead **Ships:** 300 vessels of all types—warships and transports



Cleopatra's escape
This fanciful representation of the battle shows Cleopatra fleeing treacherously—a version of Actium no longer widely accepted. The escape of the Egyptian queen was rather a pre-planned maneuver.